

acquisition, and on an unprecedented scale.

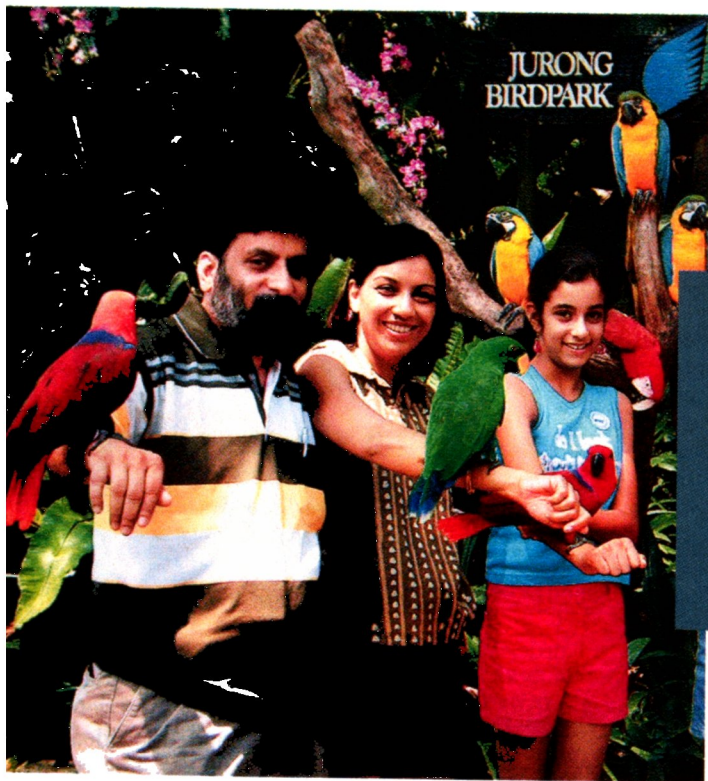
India at the start of 2008, had become home to the largest number of billionaires in Asia. It also highlighted the contrast between the rich and the poor, the old and the new, the traditional and the contemporary. The ubiquitous *aam admi*, like cartoonist Laxman's iconic Common Man, remained on the fringes, a mute and ragged onlooker to the India Story, waiting for the trickle down to trickle down. Anonymous

in Noida of a pretty, vivacious schoolgirl and the family servant, made more sensational when the bungling, insensitive police arrested the father and publicly declared that the girl, Aarushi Talwar, was killed by her father because of the sexual depravations of her parents. The media sensationalised the story showing

new rules of engagement.

In fact, 2008 could prove a landmark year, when sexual issues once considered taboo, are no longer beyond the social pale. INDIA TODAY's annual sex survey revealed that the seven deadly sins, including adultery, incest, experimental sex, prostitution and porn, were no longer social outcasts.

AARUSHI AND PARENTS IN HAPPIER TIMES (BELOW); AMIT KUMAR, THE KINGPIN OF THE KIDNEY RACKET, AFTER HIS ARREST



THE MANNER IN WHICH
TV NEWS CHANNELS
SENSATIONALISED CRIME
WAS A MIRROR TO SOCIETY:
OUR URGE TO PRY
INTO PRIVATE LIVES
WAS DISTURBING.

Health Minister Anbumani Ramadoss, who launched a series of personal crusades, some well-intentioned, others outrageous, was one of a clutch of politicians who backed the move to legalise homosexuality, as radical a move as his successful campaign to ban smoking in public places.

In totality, however, 2008 was annus horribilis. The financial crisis in mid-September was as deadly a blow as the manner in which just 10 men held an entire country hostage for close to 60 hours and caused so much death and devastation. Both were psychological strikes that impacted our pride, our confidence, our freedom, our democracy and way of life. Vulnerability and fear were words that had been largely missing from urban

that it was fast becoming the message, a disturbing one at that, as it delved ever deeper into private lives.

in their poverty, they emerged as individuals only when scandal broke, as they did when the country's biggest kidney racket was unearthed on Delhi's doorstep. Crime is a make-my-day event for TV news channels and nothing reflected that more than the sensational double murder

It was, finally, the judiciary, which decided to play a pro-active role in redefining the greyer areas of male-female relationships. A flurry of legislations and proposals focused on providing more legality to live-in relationships, an acceptance that 21st Century morality needed